

Shawn N. Cummings, Ph.D.

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Psychological Sciences (Language and Cognition) 2025

Joint affiliation with Speech, Language, and Hearing Sciences

University of Connecticut; Advisor: Dr. Rachel Theodore

Dissertation: [Linking lexically guided perceptual learning to statistical patterns in speech input](#)

M.S., Psychological Sciences (Language and Cognition) 2024

University of Connecticut; Advisor: Dr. Rachel Theodore

Thesis: Potential influences of autistic traits and perceptual acuity on lexically guided perceptual learning

Graduate Certificate in Neurobiology of Language 2024

University of Connecticut; Advisor: Dr. William Snyder

Graduate Certificate in Cognitive Science 2023

University of Connecticut; Advisor: Dr. Dimitris Xygalatis

B.A., Linguistics, University of Rochester 2021

Minors in Brain and Cognitive Sciences, English (Theatre), and Music

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Postdoctoral researcher, Language Science 2025

University of California, Irvine; Advisors: Drs. Xin Xie and Chigusa Kurumada

HONORS AND AWARDS

DOE Graduate Assistance in Areas of National Need Fellowship 2023-2025

NSF NRT Traineeship: Science of Learning & Art of Communication 2022-2023

NIH T32 Fellowship: Cognitive Neuroscience of Communication 2021-2023

Donald Shankweiler Language Sciences Award (University of Connecticut) 2021

PEER REVIEWED ARTICLES AND PROCEEDINGS

* = equal contributions; + = undergraduate student I mentored

Cummings, S.N., Jaeger, T.F., Kurumada, C., & Xie, X. (2026). [Adaptive Speech Perception: Empirical Indeterminacy and a Path Forward](#). *Proceedings of the Society for Computation in Linguistics*.

Cummings, S.N., Hodges, E.+, & Theodore, R. M. (2026). [Cumulative input sensitivity predicts both attenuation and stability of lexically guided perceptual learning](#). *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*. [OSF]

Cummings, S.N., Karboga, G., Yang, M., & Jaeger, T.F. (2025). [Compensation in audiovisual speech perception: discounting the pen in the mouth](#). *Journal of Experimental Psychology*. [OSF]

Mechtenberg, H.*, **Cummings, S. N.***, Myers, E. B., & Luthra, S. (2025). [Cents and shensibility: The role of reward in talker-specific phonetic recalibration](#). *Attention, Perception, & Psychophysics*, 1-22. [OSF]

Cummings, S.N., Duda, B.+, & Theodore, R. M. (2025). [Autistic listeners demonstrate robust lexically guided perceptual learning](#). *Autism Research*. [OSF]

Cummings, S. N., & Theodore, R. M. (2023). [Hearing is believing: Lexically guided perceptual learning is graded to reflect the quantity of evidence in speech input](#). *Cognition*, 235, 105404. [OSF]

Cummings, S. N., & Theodore, R. M. (2022). [Perceptual learning of multiple talkers: Determinants, characteristics, and limitations](#). *Attention, Perception, & Psychophysics*, 84(7), 2335-2359. [OSF]

ARTICLES UNDER REVIEW

Cummings, S. N., Udell, A.+, & Theodore, R. M. (under review). Lexically guided perceptual learning is not a task-based artifact. [OSF]

Hodges, E.+, **Cummings, S.N.**, & Theodore, R. M. (In revision). [Lexically guided perceptual learning is robust to linguistically engaging distraction](#). [OSF]

INVITED TALKS

Cummings, S.N. Modelling adaptive changes in speech perception. University of Rochester, September 2025.

Cummings, S.N. Perceptual learning and the statistics of speech input. Basque Center on Cognition, Brain, and Language, September 2025.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Cummings, S.N., Jaeger, T.F., Kurumada, C., & Xie, X. (2026, July). Adaptive Speech Perception: Empirical Indeterminacy and a Path Forward. Poster presentation at the 9th meeting of the Society for Computation in Linguistics, San Diego, California.

Ferrer, G.+, Lee, K.+, **Cummings, S.N.**, & Xie, X. (2026, June). Probing the cognitive loci of compensation for co-articulation. Poster presentation at the 20th meeting of the Association for Laboratory Phonology, Montreal, Ontario, Canada.

Cummings, S.N., & Jaeger, T.F. (2026, June). No specialized mechanisms needed? Standard perceptual compensation might explain reduced perceptual learning. Poster presentation at the 20th meeting of the Association for Laboratory Phonology, Montreal, Ontario, Canada.

Cummings, S.N., & Xie, X. (2026, May). [A novel paradigm for rapid determination of listener-specific phonetic boundaries](#). Poster presentation at the 190th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

Yuting Gu, **Cummings, S.N.**, Michelle Zhao, & Xie, X. (2026, May). Disentangling lexical decision criterion shifts from phonetic category changes in natural accent adaptation. Poster presentation at the 190th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

Jacob Bower, Yuting Gu, **Cummings, S.N.**, & Xie, X. (2026, May). Perception of Mandarin-Accented /s/-/θ/ Among L1-Mandarin Learners of English. Accepted for poster presentation at the 190th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

Cummings, S. N., & Theodore, R. M. (2024, November). Lexically guided perceptual learning is not a task-based artifact. Oral presentation at the 65th Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, New York, New York.

Cummings, S. N. (2024, November). Lexically guided perceptual learning is robust! But what is it? Oral presentation at the EDULANG meeting on Variation and Diversity in Language Acquisition and Processing, Storrs, Connecticut.

Cummings, S. N., Duda, B.+, Medeiros, W., & Theodore, R. M. (2024, June). Potential influences of autistic traits and perceptual acuity on lexically guided perceptual learning. Oral presentation at the 9th Conference of the Scandinavian Association for Language and Cognition, Trondheim, Norway.

Cummings, S. N., Duda, B.+, Medeiros, W., & Theodore, R. M. (2024, May). Potential influences of autistic traits and perceptual acuity on lexically guided perceptual learning. Poster presentation at the 186th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Ottawa, Ontario, Canada.

Giovannone, N., **Cummings, S. N.**, García-Sierra, A., Magnuson, J. S., & Theodore, R. M. (2023, November). Early neural encoding of acoustic-phonetic information is consistent across language ability. Poster presentation at the 64th Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, San Francisco, CA.

Giovannone, N., **Cummings, S. N.**, García-Sierra, A., Magnuson, J. S., & Theodore, R. M. (2023, October). Early neural encoding of acoustic-phonetic information is consistent across language ability. Poster presentation at the 15th Annual Meeting of the Society for the Neurobiology of Language, Marseille, France.

Cummings, S. N., Choi, J. Y., Shattuck-Hufnagel, S., & Theodore, R. M. (2023, May). Linking lexically guided perceptual learning to statistical patterns in speech input. Poster presentation at the 184th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Chicago, Illinois.

Hodges, E., **Cummings, S. N.**, & Theodore, R. M. (2023, May). Easy come, easy go: Examining the stability of lexically guided perceptual learning over time. Poster presentation at the 184th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Chicago, Illinois.

Cummings, S.N., Karboga, G., Yang, M., & Jaeger, T.F. (2021, November) Causal Inference in the Perception and Learning of Audio-Visually Presented Speech. Poster presentation at the 62nd Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

* = course designed by me

Instructor:

*SLHS 6367: Topics in Hearing and Speech Science

Spring 2025

UNIV 1800: University Learning Skills

Fall 2024

Teaching Assistant:

SLHS 2156Q: Speech and Hearing Science

Fall 2023, 2024, Spring 2024, 2025

Guest Lectures:

University of California, Irvine: Advanced Skills for Language Science III

Spring 2026

University of Connecticut: Seminar in Career Skills For Life After Grad School

Spring 2026

University of California, Irvine: Introduction to Speech Science

Fall 2025

University of Rochester: Speech Perception as an Adaptive Mechanism

Fall 2025

University of Connecticut: Current Topics in Developmental Psychology

Spring 2024

University of Rochester: Undergraduate Research in Cognitive Science

Spring 2022

SERVICE

Ad hoc Reviewer

Applied Psycholinguistics; Glossa Psycholinguistics; Journal of the Acoustical Society of America; Language and Speech; Language, Cognition, and Neuroscience; Language Learning; Journal of Experimental Psychology: General; Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance; Attention, Perception, & Psychophysics

Reviewer

National Council on Undergraduate Research 2023

Student Facilitator 2023-2024

“Talk Shop” series, University of Connecticut

Poster Session Chair 2023

186th meeting of the Acoustical Society of America

Member, J-Term Committee 2021-2022

Science of Learning and Art of Communication Program, University of Connecticut

Member, Organizing Committee 2021

LangFest, University of Connecticut

SKILLS

Programming: R (proficient), Python (proficient), Stan (novice), Javascript (novice), MATLAB (novice)

Experimental design: Gorilla (proficient), OpenSesame (novice), PsychoPy (novice)

Acoustic analysis: Praat (proficient, annotation and scripting)

Electrophysiology recording: Brainvision product suite (proficient)

Language: English (native fluency), Spanish (rudimentary), American Sign Language (rudimentary)